

leadership at the back. Czechia's challenge lies in the order of its fixtures: Korea Republic first, South Africa in Atlanta next, and Mexico at the Azteca last. It cannot afford to leave its work until the final night.

South Africa is the lowest-ranked team in the group, but not one to be dismissed lightly. Hugo Broos has built Bafana Bafana around collective discipline, with Ronwen Williams in goal, Teboho Mokoena in midfield and Lyle Foster leading the attack. Its return after 16 years is significant, but the opening match against Mexico at altitude represents the toughest possible start. Realistically, South Africa's hopes of staying alive rest on taking something from Czechia in Atlanta and Korea Republic in Monterrey.

Group A, then, is not about one giant and three passengers. It is about a host under pressure, two technically accomplished challengers and an African side organised enough to complicate the race. Mexico should progress. Korea Republic and Czechia appear best placed to fight for the other automatic spot, while South Africa will hope the expanded format leaves the door open for a third-place escape.



Patrik Schick (Czechia)

Schick is Czechia's clearest route to goals. Strong in the air, composed in the box and capable from distance, he gives Koubek's side a focal point. His fitness and finishing could determine whether Czechia returns home early or reaches the knockout rounds.



Teboho Mokoena (South Africa)

Mokoena is the balancing force in South Africa's midfield. His passing range, ball-winning ability and set-piece threat make him vital to Broos' structure. Against stronger teams, South Africa will need him to slow matches down and choose the right moments to relieve pressure.

SQUADS

Mexico

Goalkeepers: Raul Rangel, Guillermo Ochoa, Carlos Acevedo

Defenders: Jorge Sanchez, Israel Reyes, Cesar Montes, Johan Vasquez, Jesus Gallardo, Mateo Chavez

Midfielders: Erik Lira, Orbelin Pineda, Alvaro Fidalgo, Brian Gutierrez, Luis Romo, Edson Alvarez, Obed Vargas, Gilberto Mora, Luis Chavez

Forwards: Roberto Alvarado, Cesar Huerta, Alexis Vega, Julian Quinones, Guillermo Martinez, Armando Gonzalez, Santiago Gimenez, Raul Jimenez

Korea Republic

Goalkeepers: Jo Hyeon-woo, Kim Seung-gyu, Song Bum-keun

Defenders: Kim Min-jae, Cho Wi-je, Lee Han-beom, Kim Tae-hyeon, Park Jin-seob, Lee Ki-hyuk, Lee Tae-seok, Seol Young-woo, Jens Castrop, Kim Moon-hwan

Midfielders: Yang Hyun-jun, Paik Seung-ho, Hwang In-beom, Kim Jin-kyu, Bae Jun-ho, Eom Ji-sung, Hwang Hee-chan, Lee Dong-gyeong, Lee Jae-sung, Lee Kang-in

Forwards: Oh Hyeon-gyu, Son Heung-min, Cho Gue-sung

Czechia

Goalkeepers: Lukas Hornicek, Matej Kovar, Jindrich Stanek

Defenders: Stepan Chaloupek, Vladimir Coufal, David Doudera, Tomas Holes, Robin Hranac, David Jurasek, Ladislav Krejci, Jaroslav Zeleny, David Zima

Midfielders: Lukas Cerv, Vladimir Darida, Lukas Provod, Michal Sadilek, Hugo Sochurek, Alexandr Sojka, Tomas Soucek, Pavel Sulc, Denis Visinsky

Forwards: Tomas Chory, Mojmir Chytil, Adam Hlozek, Jan Kuchta, Patrik Schick

South Africa

Goalkeepers: Ronwen Williams, Ricardo Goss, Sipho Chaine

Defenders: Khuliso Mudau, Aubrey Modiba, Khulumani Ndamane, Olwethu Makhanya, Bradley Cross, Thabang Matuludi, Nkosinathi Sibisi, Kamogelo Sebelebele, Ime Okon, Samukele Kabini, Mbekezeli Mbokazi

Midfielders: Teboho Mokoena, Jayden Adams, Thabane Mkhabela, Sphephelo Sithole

Forwards: Oswin Appollis, Tshepang Moremi, Evidence Makgopa, Relebohile Mofokeng, Lyle Foster, Iqraam Rayners, Themba Zwane, Thapelo Maseko